Battling the Black Scourge

***Happiness delivery:** A victim of Kala Azar in her pre-teens, Pinki has taken it upon herself to create awareness about the dreaded disease in her home district, Deoria, in UP*

By **PRASHANT SRIVASTAVA**



BE WARY Pinki (centre) with students at one of her *pathshala* classes

PINKI KI PATHSHALA
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It's a cold morning at the government school in Deoria district's Banghata block, and a group of 30 students are listening to a girl not much older than themselves. She is 19-year-old Pinki Chauhan, who runs Pinki ki Pathshala, as part of an awareness programme on 'Kala Azar' or 'black fever', a vector-borne disease caused by the protozoan parasite, *Leishmania donovani*, which can be fatal if not treated. A victim of Kala Azar herself, Pinki has now become a household name across Uttar Pradesh's Deoria district for the informal classes she takes in government schools to raise awareness about the disease in the region. She not only gives details about the disease, but also engages students through a series of games so that she can effectively drive home her mission and message—'*Hansna bhi, jagrook karna bhi* (Smile but also be on your guard)'.

Pinki "caught the black fever" in 2015 when she was just 12. She recovered, but a year later again fell victim to kala azar's sequential infection—post-kala azar dermal leishmaniasis (PKDL)—in which the parasite invades the skin. It took years to recover fully, a difficult time when she took the decision to do what she could to create awareness about the disease. The chance came in November 2021 when she got involved with the UP government's community engagement efforts to create awareness against lymphatic filariasis (a painful, disfiguring disease otherwise known as elephantiasis) and dermal leishmaniasis. Since then, she and her pathshala have visited several villages of Deoria.

Says Pinki, "I am a victim myself so I know the pain and the struggles. I realised that few people know what causes kala azar (the disease is spread by sandflies). Nor do they realise how serious it can be. Apart from taking classes at schools, I now cycle around the district in a bid to reach out to at least two dozen people every day. I talk about the disease, its warning signs and symptoms and prevention, besides telling people who to contact if they have doubts." She feels people know about mosquitoes, but not so much about sandflies, which are 50-

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"Staying fit and healthy is essential to be happy. And to stay fit, one must be aware about lurking maladies. Awareness is key for a healthy future"

PINKI CHAUHAN, Kala Azar awareness campaigner